

RAJWANT RAWAT

can be earned through SWAYAM, benefitting rural students with limited access to facilities.

The Common University Entrance Test (CUET), introduced in 2022, provides a level playing field for students. They don't need to score 99 per cent to secure admission. It has helped students from rural and remote areas by allowing exams in 12 Indian languages, increasing diversity in top universities and enhancing national integration.

We will soon announce guidelines for internship-embedded undergraduate programmes, significantly impacting employment opportunities. For instance, a student in a four-year undergraduate programme can study for two years at the university and work as an apprentice in a related industry for the remaining two years.

Another reform gaining traction is the 'professor of practice' initiative. Experienced professionals, even without formal educational qualifications, can teach in higher educational institutions. Currently, 250 professors of practice have been appointed nationwide.

We have also announced a national credit framework integrating school education, skill and vocational education and higher education. Once a child is admitted to school, they are onboarded into this framework. These credits offer students flexibility in shaping their careers. For example, previously, if a student completed an ITI diploma or a certificate course after the 10th grade, they had no option to get admission to a university or pursue a PhD without starting over through regular courses. Now, an ITI diploma-holder can earn credits through bridge courses, obtain a certificate equivalent to 10+2 and join a university.

We have introduced new regulations for deemed universities, replacing restrictive norms. We also allow students to pursue two academic programmes simultaneously.

Last year, we launched the Malaviya Mission Teacher Training Programme to train teachers in new pedagogical approaches required for implementing the National Education Policy 2020. Additionally, we created the CU Chayan Portal to simplify the application process for teaching positions in central universities, centralising all recruitment advertisements and helping the UGC monitor vacancies.

"INDIA HAS ONLY 18% OF THE RESEARCHERS CHINA HAS, AND 5% OF WHAT THE US HAS. BUT INDIA IS THE 3RD LARGEST IN TERMS OF PUBLISHED PAPERS"

Q. Why is it that no Indian university figures among the top 10 or 20 in global rankings?

Understanding how global agencies rank higher educational institutions is crucial. Around 40 per cent of the weightage is given to peer perception, 10 per cent to employer perception and 20 per cent to research output, the remaining allocated to various other parameters. While Indian universities may not yet be in the top 10, their presence in global rankings is increasing rapidly. With the implementation of the NEP and various other reforms in higher education, the situation will improve. Consider this. The total number of researchers in India is about 18 per cent of those in China and only about 5 per cent of those in the US. However, India is the third largest in terms of published papers, and the increasing citations of our papers indicate the rising global status of our universities.

Q. A major issue in higher education is the vacancies in universities. The UGC has recently reminded universities to fill these posts. What has been the response?

Faculty selection is often a complex and lengthy process, requiring universities to recruit teachers with the necessary expertise who may not be readily available. Having said that, some state universities have filled vacancies with contractual teachers who may not have the incentive to remain as committed to teaching and research as a regular faculty. State governments must prioritise recruiting regular faculty members. As a regulatory body, we can only remind and request universities to fill these positions.

Q. Critics argue that the UGC's changes to PhD admissions curtail university autonomy. Is that true?

Universities can independently admit candidates who clear the Junior Research Fellowship (JRF) to their PhD programmes. The UGC provides an additional option: 70 per cent weightage to UGC-NET scores and 30 per cent to university interviews, benefitting students without JRF. This process is not mandatory. The four-year undergraduate to PhD pathway is a global practice. However, a four-year undergraduate student does not directly proceed to a PhD, as many might assume. The student must first earn their undergraduate degree with a 75 per cent score and then clear the UGC-NET or a university-conducted test. If they fail to do so, they will need to complete one year of post-graduation, score at least 55 per cent, and then clear the UGC-NET or a university-conducted test.

Q. The UGC has also introduced the UGC (Fitness of Colleges for Receiving Grants) Rules, 2024, for HEIs, replacing the 1975 guidelines. Some